

Does grid governance represent a rationalisation of state authority, or reconstruct patrimonial dependency in a new institutional guise?

Jiatong LIU

Introduciton

During the COVID-19 lockdowns (2020–2022), grid governance became the main mechanism through which local governments implemented “dynamic zero-COVID” policies. Grid workers were responsible for contact tracing, monitoring residents’ movements, distributing supplies, and enforcing quarantine rules. In many cities, neighborhoods were divided into thousands of grids to ensure close surveillance and rapid response.

The system demonstrated strong mobilisation capacity. However, the pandemic also exposed certain tensions. Grid workers were granted considerable discretionary power at the community level, often with limited formal oversight. In some cases, residents experienced this not simply as service provision, but as intrusive control. This raises a broader theoretical question: what kind of authority does grid governance actually represent?

Rather than focusing on whether the state has become stronger or weaker, this paper examines whether the form of authority has changed. Is grid governance a more rational-legal and bureaucratised system, or does it reproduce personalised and dependency-based relations similar to earlier governance models?

Problématique

This paper therefore asks does grid governance represent a rationalisation of state authority , or does it reconstruct patrimonial dependency in a new institutional guise, relying once more on personal relationships between grid workers and residents, and on party-state co-optation of community elite

To explore this question, the paper draws on Max Weber’s distinction between patrimonial

and rational-legal authority. The danwei (work unit) system in Maoist China serves as a historical reference point. As described by Walder (1986), the danwei embedded state power into everyday life through organised dependency. Access to housing, welfare, and career mobility was tied to the work unit, making exit difficult.

Market reforms in the 1990s weakened this structure. With housing privatisation and labour mobility, many urban residents became detached from danwei-based control. The grid system emerged later as a new form of grassroots governance designed to manage increasingly mobile urban populations.

The key question, therefore, is whether the grid system represents a bureaucratic rationalisation of governance, or whether it reconstructs a more personalised form of authority at the community level. Existing research suggests that the answer may not be entirely one or the other, but possibly a hybrid form.

Methodology

This paper employs a qualitative, literature-based methodology. It does not generate primary data but instead conducts a close analytical reading and critical synthesis of existing secondary scholarship to develop an original argument about the transformation of state authority in urban China. This approach is appropriate given that the empirical phenomena in question (the danwei and the grid system) have each generated a substantial body of rigorously researched academic literature upon which this paper can draw.

The paper proceeds in three analytical steps. First, it establishes the danwei as a historical baseline by reconstructing its institutional logic and mode of authority through close engagement with the foundational literature (Walder 1986; Whyte and Parish 1984; Bjorklund 1986). Second, it analyses the grid governance system as the primary object of inquiry, examining its institutional design, stated rationale, and empirically observed functioning through Tang Beibei (2020) and Mittelstaedt (2022), among others. Third, it places both systems in comparative-theoretical dialogue, using Weber's framework to

interrogate the nature of each mode of authority and to assess the extent to which the transition represents rationalisation, patrimonial reconstitution, or a hybrid that neither category fully captures. Read (2000) provides an important historical bridge, tracing the institutional lineage from residents' committees to the grid system. Throughout, the paper maintains an openness to the evidence rather than imposing a predetermined conclusion.

Bibliography

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